Keelwater: product lifecycle diagnosis and 90-day plan

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Assumed (invented or from conversation): Gong, Fireflies, Intercom with Fin, FullStory, HubSpot, Notion, Shortcut, and Metabase on production Postgres; customer data stays in Keelwater's AWS VPC, fully audited; the platform's leading harness cannot run always-on agents; the factory launches next quarter; a head of data engineering is being hired; open-weight models will be self-hosted; PMs can give a labelling half-day.

As build cost falls, the constraint moves left to deciding what to build and right to release and adoption. Coding and testing are about 25-35% of idea-to-launch time (Bain, FOUND[1]). Halving needs 50 points, so even zero build time leaves about 20 to find in Decide, Define and release (INFERRED).

1. Where the lifecycle loses time and value

- Feedback arrives by four routes and nobody consolidates it, so PMs hear the loudest account.
- A third of PM time goes on status, data chasing and "what shipped?" (self-reported).
- Each tool computes its own metrics.
- With no shared spec, engineers and agents guess at intent.
- Decisions go unwritten, so settled arguments reopen.
- Across 655 firms, coding agents raised PR volume about 36% and submission-to-approval time 56% (Harvard/Jellyfish working paper, FOUND).
- Daily releases push change cost onto customers, who retrain claims handlers.

Every handoff runs through someone's memory or a meeting; AI sped up the steps and left the joins alone.

Evidence missing: value-stream timing per squad, PR review wait, signal share per route, each tool's metrics side by side, retraining cost per release, a two-week PM time diary.

2. The lifecycle in an agentic world

Agents read, draft and check; named people pass five gates.

Stage	Agents and pipelines	Gate (who)	Artefact
Sense	Nightly Signal Engine: triage, extraction, verified quotes	None; 40 drops audited weekly	Insights
Decide	Clustering, formula ranking, cited briefs, judges	Accept (PM)	Decision log entry
Define	Intent-doc agent, design-system mockup	Sign-off (Trio)	Intent doc, factory job
Build	Platform factory	Merge (engineers)	PR behind a flag
Release	Bundle assembler: notes, notices, customer impact	Bundle (PM, customer success)	Bundle manifest
Enable	Help articles, videos, post-call briefs	Comms (product marketing manager)	Articles, videos
Learn	Adoption against the intent doc's outcome metric	None	Outcome report

Handoffs. Each stage passes a typed artefact with a status. Agents move items only into states their stage owns, only named people pass gates, and every move is logged. The intent doc (problem, evidence, outcome metric, acceptance criteria, non-goals) and its factory job form the platform contract; the job cites evidence by reference, so quotes stay in the VPC.

Noise and accuracy. A sub-cent decision model drops chatter; a weekly sample of 40 drops measures what it misses. Code checks every quote, citation and number. Three judges from another model family test faithfulness, signal and duplication; each stays "calibrating" until 50 blind PM labels per class put the 95% lower bound of its true-positive and true-negative rates at 0.75.

Deploy daily, release in bundles. Code ships daily behind flags; customers get an announced monthly bundle with a preview, evidence of the controlled change the EU's Digital Operational Resilience Act, Art. 9 expects (FOUND). Customers then wait up to four weeks, so I track idea-to-production-behind-flag and idea-to-customer separately and offer opt-in early-access cohorts.

3. Shared infrastructure

Standard is whatever crosses squads, feeds a comparison or must survive an audit.

Standard (product ops owns)	Set by each squad
Signal schema and core taxonomy	Taxonomy extensions, ranking weights
Intent-doc template, factory job schema, decision log	Own skills, extra template sections
Model gateway and routing rules	Prompts within guardrails
Eval harness and judge registry	Judge thresholds above the shared floor
Telemetry, audit, access control	Digest cadence, in-squad visibility
One metric dictionary	Squad metrics, defined in it

4. The first 90 days

Everything runs in the VPC on a scheduled job runner that product ops owns, moving onto the platform harness if it gains scheduling. My ask: one engineer seconded for 90 days and platform support for the intake API; without the engineer, day 90 covers three squads, not five.

Day 30. Running: the Signal Engine nightly for a volunteer pilot squad on tickets and sales calls; a Shortcut "what shipped" digest for every squad. Users: the pilot Trio; all PMs for a labelling half-day (about 250 labels). Learned: signal share per route, value-stream baselines. Go: the pilot PM accepts three of the top 10, reviewed in 30 minutes.

Day 60. Running: all routes plus sessions (code cuts idle time, a small model picks windows); intent-doc handoff for two squads; the decision log; flags and bundle manifest in the digest; a bundle pilot with three large customers. Users: two Trios, customer success. Learned: acceptance, judge agreement, review churn. Go: acceptance above 30% and no pilot customer leaves bundles.

Day 90. Running: intake for three to five squads, by staffing; outtake drafts (release notes, help articles, change notices, follow-up briefs); the intent-doc schema ready for launch. Users: PMs, product marketing, sales. Learned: pilot against control; where the bottleneck moved.

Adoption is the harder half:

- The VP Product sponsors it; the pilot squad volunteers.
- I give first: the digest removes status reporting before PMs label.
- Labelling happens in the Monday review (blind label panel, noise sample).
- The board replaces the weekly feedback meeting.
- The factory accepts only signed intent docs.
- Metrics at 30/60/90 days: weekly active PMs, % of decisions with written rationale, % of customer-visible changes flagged.

5. What I will not touch, and the platform contract

- The coding-agent harness is the platform team's; a second would split two engineers.
- Engineering owns code-review policy; I supply review-wait data.
- Squad structure: I have no authority, and changing it alongside tooling would hide which worked.
- The design system, which designers already prototype on.
- The metric dictionary waits for the head of data engineering.

I ask the platform team for an intake API, a co-owned versioned factory job schema, gateway access with per-team cost tags, OpenTelemetry into self-hosted Phoenix, previews and demo videos, and per-customer flag cohorts. I own the lifecycle agents and job runner, schemas, evals, judges and adoption.

6. What to tell leadership and what to measure

Tell the board that coding speed alone cannot halve delivery: in a McKinsey study of 40 PMs, a 40% productivity gain moved time to market about 5% (FOUND). In 90 days expect status work down from a third of PM time to under a tenth, feedback-to-decision in days, and every build decision written. Halving is a 12-month question.

Before adding squads, compare pilot and control squads on both lead times, status hours, acceptance, judge agreement and review wait. My recommendation changes if:

- acceptance stays below 30% after calibration: rework taxonomy and ranking with PMs first;
- review dominates lead time: fund review capacity (smaller PRs, agent pre-review) before more intake;
- customers reject bundles: give each customer flag-level control instead.

Part 2, the working Signal Engine, is in this repo; start at the README.

1. FOUND: in the cited source. INFERRED: my reasoning from sources.